

Pediatric CT research elevates public health concerns: low-dose radiation issues are highly politicized.

This article presents an analysis of issues related to low-dose radiation, with a focus on pediatric computed tomography (CT). It references several early studies that are seldom quoted in radiation research papers, then quantifies the excess lifetime fatal cancer yield attributable to an estimated 6.5 million pediatric abdominal CT scans. The authors highlight an important policy document issued jointly by the National Cancer Institute and the Society for Pediatric Radiology--specifically, its conclusion that a small dose from CT represents "a public health concern." Finally, the article identifies several contentious issues and proposes policy initiatives that, if implemented, could result in significant reductions of future radiogenic cancers and chronic injuries. The authors call for discussions between professional radiology societies and public interest health organizations, thereby involving all stakeholders.